



Cobbler 2 Cobbler Peer Mentoring Program

Developing peer leaders and creating a system of change is about putting in the time and energy to prepare and train a diverse group of students. When I am asked how I built a successful peer leadership and prevention program, my response is the same every time: Train them, trust them, and get out of the way! – Tim McGowan, Rapid City Central High School



Members of the Cobbler 2 Cobbler peer mentoring program at Rapid City Central High School join other volunteers before a Safe Halloween event.

Rapid City Central High School, a school with about 1900 students and one of three high schools in the Rapid City Area Schools, experienced more than its share of tragedy in the space of a few short years. Between September 2007 and September 2011, the school community endured 28 deaths, including several teen suicides and other students and staff members who died in accidents or from illness. In the larger Rapid City area contained within Pennington County, South Dakota, a total of 14 teenagers committed suicide in the 30 months prior to March 2008. Students, staff, and families were in an unrelenting state of shock and grief.

Counselor Tim McGowan perceived that adult-led programming was insufficient and largely ineffective in helping students to process the severe stresses they were facing. He and others applied for and received a grant to implement Sources of Strength, a student-driven, research-based model for suicide prevention. The first training for peer leaders was conducted in November 2008, and in spring of the following year, peer leaders became the core of the school's mentoring program. Although the grant ended several years ago, McGowan continued to use the program and enlarged it into a peer mentoring program that ensures that all students at the school are connected to caring peers and adults, and that no student, even in a large and diverse school like Central High, remains isolated and invisible. The program, now called Cobbler 2 Cobbler after the school's mascot, has been replicated in a number of other area schools.

Since September 2011, there have been no teen suicides in Rapid City. District leaders suggest a possible link between this fact and the implementation of peer programs that have created a network of support and assistance for high school students.

Research basis

As program developer and director for Cobbler 2 Cobbler, McGowan has always been concerned with ensuring that the entire program structure is based upon sound research. The efficacy of the Sources of Strength Suicide Prevention Program, which formed the basis of Cobbler 2 Cobbler, was validated in a study conducted by Dr. Peter Wyman from the University of Rochester and colleagues (2010). The study, the largest randomized controlled trial of peer programming, took place in 18 high schools (six urban and 12 rural). Schools were randomly assigned to receive an immediate intervention or serve as a wait-list control. A total of 453 peer leaders and a representative sample of 2,675 students were surveyed before the Sources of Strength program began and four months after program implementation.

The study found that peer leaders in the program, working in conjunction with supportive adults, increased their sense of connectedness to adults and to school engagement. Other findings from the study indicated that:

- Trained peers were four times more likely than untrained peers to refer a suicidal friend to adults for assistance;
- Perceptions shifted among the entire student population in schools using the Sources of Strength program, with youth becoming more accepting of seeking help and finding adult support for suicidal youth;
- Students were able to name more trusted adults;
- Training adults by itself was not likely to have a significant impact on the adults' ability to identify and respond to suicidal youth; and
- Students considering suicide were the least likely to seek adult help.

The study also discovered that the establishment of positive peer social networks in the school environment not only served to protect against suicides, but diminished a number of other harmful behaviors including bullying, substance abuse, mental health issues, and violence.

Dr. Wyman and Mark LoMurray, founder of the Sources of Strength program, told McGowan the study also suggested that the presence of a single trusted adult in a student's life could cut maladaptive decision-making by half, while having two trusted adults in a student's life could virtually eliminate most unhealthy decision-making. (McGowan, 2015)



LEFT: A Cobbler 2 Cobbler student reads to children at a local daycare center. RIGHT: Two Native American students from Cobbler 2 Cobbler assist at a bowling event in Rapid City for Special Olympics.

Other research informed the program design (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2009; Fein et al., 2004). McGowan found that all the research pointed to common themes. These included a sense of connectedness and the tendency of adolescents to listen to and seek help from peers as being key factors in prevention. Other themes from the research were the need for positive and appropriate behavior to be modeled and not just described, the vital importance of students connecting with trusted adults through the building of authentic and caring relationships, and the provision of opportunities to build a community of connectedness involving all people and utilizing the power of social networks.

Program design

In the spring of each year, students who want to become mentors the following year go through a four-hour workshop during which students reflect on the reasons they want to become involved. If after the workshop students choose to participate, they enroll in a Peer Leadership/Mentoring credit course that counts toward graduation requirements. Students can take the class one or more semesters during their junior and senior years. The quality and quantity of the training, says McGowan, is what makes the program successful. He describes how successive rounds of training help students to understand their role as well as its limitations. The largest part of the training, he notes, is going through numerous "What if" scenarios and exploring how students might respond to a variety of situations in a responsible and ethical fashion. About 175 students each year are involved as peer mentors.

As a consequence of the trainings, all peer mentors and leaders are keenly aware of how and when they can help other students, and when they need to refer a student to a trained counselor in the building. "There is a high level of trust and accountability in the program," states McGowan. "Everyone, from my school board to the superintendent to the building principal, knows that the students are trained and will come to me when there is an issue they are not qualified to handle." He notes that peer mentor programs can easily fail if students do not honor the essential importance of confidentiality or if they provide inappropriate guidance to their peers.

The Peer Leadership/Mentoring course runs five days a week. On Mondays and Tuesdays, students are focused on discussing and understanding social and emotional issues including relationship skills, responsible decision-making, respectful communication, supporting others through difficult periods, and hearing and acknowledging different perspectives. Every Wednesday features a training to build students' skills as mentors and leaders. On Thursdays and Fridays, the peer mentors lead freshmen seminars along with McGowan and freshmen counselor Jenny Griffin. The freshmen seminars are highly experiential in nature, and are structured to promote a feeling of ease and safety for participants. Every freshman in the school attends a seminar once every other week. All students in the school, regardless of their class level, know they can turn to a peer mentor if they need academic tutoring or time to talk about a personal issue.

Cobbler 2 Cobbler peer mentors not only lead the freshmen seminars and provide individual tutoring and mentoring, but are engaged in a number of other service projects in their school and community. Each year, peer leaders help to fundraise, organize games, and oversee volunteers and security for a "Safe Halloween" party at the school. In 2014/15, about 300 students volunteered to help with the event. Peer mentors play a large role in the local Special Olympics, organizing several hundred students each year to assist with bowling, basketball, and track activities. Peer mentors also organize speakers for a grade 10 career fair and coordinate prevention workshops for all Central High juniors.

McGowan is often asked how the school has established such a popular and effective program. "I have to tell people, it's not a kit," he explains. "It's an approach of how you work with students in real and authentic ways. Students need to have a real voice and take real responsibility. It's not a quick fix."

Native American involvement



Students from Cobbler 2 Cobbler at the South Dakota Indian Education Summit in 2014.

While approximately 22% of the student population at Central High School is Native American, Native students form more than one-third—about 35–40%—of the mentors in the Cobbler 2 Cobbler program. Native students explain their disproportionately large representation in the program by saying that they "know and live the struggles kids are going through" and have the ability to help others and lift them up. They also feel that because the program is a nontraditional one, minority students can easily contribute their efforts and have a significant impact in peers. While no special attempts are made to recruit students from any particular racial or ethnic background, the welcoming of students from all segments of the school community ensures a diverse representation.

In addition to their regular responsibilities in the peer mentoring program, Native students have given several conference presentations at venues such as the South Dakota Indian Education Summit and North Dakota Indian Youth

Leadership Conference. They were the first-ever student group to present at the National Dropout Prevention Conference for Native and Tribal Communities.

The staff and students in Cobbler 2 Cobbler are entering into a partnership with public and private high schools on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation, which is located in the southwestern part of the state. The partnership is designed to provide ongoing training and support and foster peer mentorship programs that will prevent the teen suicides that have become all too common. The reservation has long experienced a high rate of teen suicides, with an attempted youth suicide rate that is 7-10 times the national average. In a three month period, from December 2014 through February 2015, there were more than 100 attempted suicides and nine youth who took their own lives. (Lakota Children's Enrichment, 2016)

McGowan and school administrators and counselors from Pine Ridge are hopeful that a peer mentoring program based on Sources of Strength and the Cobbler 2 Cobbler model can effectively counter the sense of hopelessness and despair experienced by too many students on the reservation. "We want to think of Rapid City and Pine Ridge as being parts of one community," says McGowan. "We are joining together to create a sense of safety and connection for all our young people."

For more information on the Cobbler 2 Cobbler peer mentoring program, contact Tin McGowan at 605-394-4063 ext. 3 or Tim.McGowan@k12.sd.us. All photographs and graphics displayed in the article are shown courtesy of Tim McGowan and Central High School in Rapid City, South Dakota.

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